

Interview Guide for Skill Hires

An EWOR Checklist

Step 1

Interview Preparation



General Questions to Ask Yourself:

- What specific technical skills are non-negotiable for this role?
- How will we objectively measure these capabilities?
- What level of skill proficiency is required versus preferred?
- Who on our team is qualified to evaluate these technical abilities?
- What technical gaps exist in our current team that this hire must fill?
- How much domain-specific knowledge is required versus transferable skills?
- What evidence of past performance will convince us of capability?



Specific Prep / To Dos Per Interviewee:

- Review the candidate's portfolio, work samples, or technical contributions.
- Prepare skill-verification questions based on claimed expertise.
- Create role-specific technical exercises or case studies.
- Design technical problem scenarios relevant to your specific challenges.
- Assign specialist interviewers to evaluate different skill areas.
- Brief interviewers on specific claims in the resume to verify.

Step 2

The Interview



Core Questions to Assess Capabilities:

- "Walk me through your most significant project at [Company X]. What was your specific role?"
- "What technical challenges did you face at [Company Y] and how did you overcome them?"
- "How have you scaled [specific process/system] in your previous role?"
- "What's the difference between a good, great, and exceptional [role title] in your opinion?"
- "Can you provide an example of when you demonstrated [exceptional quality defined]?"
- "Who's the best [role title] you've ever worked with? What made them so effective?"
- "You hadn't been a [role title] before this position. How did you adapt and learn?"
- "What technical frameworks or methodologies have you implemented successfully?"
- "Is [Company X] a buy, sell, or hold at the current price?" (for financial roles)
- "What is your plan for attacking [specific job challenge], and what evidence supports your ability to execute?"
- "Review our current [system/process/product] and provide recommendations for improvement"
- "Design a solution for [specific technical challenge] we're currently facing"



Core Questions to Assess Impact and Results:

- "What metrics did you use to measure success in your previous role?"
- "Can you quantify the impact of your work at [Company Z]?"
- "What was your biggest accomplishment at [Company X]?" (then drill down on specifics)
- "What systems or processes did you build that continued after your departure?"
- "How did you influence strategic decisions in your previous organization?"
- "What was your worst failure? What would you do differently now?"
- "What were you known for professionally at your last company?"



Core Questions to Assess Team and Leadership:

- "Who was your best hire and why? Where are they now?"
- "How have you developed technical talent on your team?"
- "How do you evaluate technical competence when hiring?"
- "How do you balance technical excellence with delivery timelines?"
- "How have you handled technical disagreements within your team?"
- "What technical mentorship have you provided to junior team members?"



"Intuition" Evaluation Checklist:

- Provides specific technical details without prompting.
- Explains complex concepts clearly and simply.
- Acknowledges limitations in knowledge areas outside expertise.
- Demonstrates systematic problem-solving approach.
- Shows appropriate depth of knowledge in claimed specialty areas.
- Can translate technical concepts for non-technical audience.

Step 3

Post-Interview Work



Checklist:

- Document technical assessment results immediately after interview.
- Compare demonstrated skills against required capabilities.
- Conduct a technical debrief with all specialist interviewers.
- Identify technical areas requiring verification through references.
- Design targeted technical exercises if additional validation is needed.
- Verify specific claimed achievements through references.
- Continue reference calls until technical capabilities are fully validated.



Technical Reference Call Template:

- Establish technical relationship context: "How did you work with the candidate?"
- "What specific technical contributions did they make to your organization?"
- "How would you rate their technical expertise in [specific skill area]?"
- "What was their most significant technical achievement working with you?"
- "How did they handle technical challenges or setbacks?"
- "How would you rank their technical abilities compared to others in similar roles?"
- "What areas of technical growth would you recommend for them?"
- "Would you trust them to lead a critical technical initiative? Why or why not?"
- "What specific evidence can you provide of their impact on [claimed achievement]?"

Step 4

Making the Decision



Checklist:

- Compare demonstrated capabilities against original requirements.
- Evaluate the quality and relevance of past accomplishments.
- Assess technical skill depth versus breadth based on role needs.
- Consider both immediate contribution potential and growth trajectory.
- Weigh technical excellence against minimum cultural alignment needs.
- Determine any skill gaps that would require additional support.
- Establish clear expectations for initial technical contributions.
- Document the specific capabilities that justify the hiring decision.

